Fairness

By Chinelo Okparanta

INTRODUCTION

Whether we like to admit it or not, our global society is segregated -- divided by tribe, religion, even skin color. Colorism, much like racism, is a form of discrimination that regards darker skin as inferior, ugly and unacceptable and lighter or "fair" skin as superior. All over the world, people with darker skin tones attempt to gain social acceptance by bleaching their skin. It is not uncommon to see videos of people peeling off layers of their skin to reveal a lighter hue. In fact, according to a 2023 World Health Organization report, 77% of Nigerian women use skin bleaching products.*

In this selection, Nigerian author Chinelo Okparanta shares a tale from her youth even though it's ugly – inferior -- unacceptable. Her actions were all in the quest for. . . Fairness by Chinelo Okparanta

CHINELO: **(Pgs 32-40)** We gather outside the classroom in the break between morning and afternoon lectures. We stand on the concrete steps, chewing groundnuts and meat pies, all of us with the same dark skin, matching, like the uniforms we wear. All of us, excepting Onyechi of course, because her skin has now turned color, and we are eager to know how. She no longer belongs. She is now one of the others, one of the girls with fair skin.

BARNA: *(chuckling in disbelief; she claps her hands, eyes wide)* 'Chi mo! My God! How fast the miracle!

CHINELO: Onyechi shakes her head, tells us that it was no miracle at all. She tells us of the bleach. I listen and nod, trying to catch every bit of the formula. Our skin is the colour not of ripe pawpaw peels, but of its seeds. We are thirsty for fairness. I think of returning home and telling Eno.

Hours later, I sit on a stool outside. Ekaite is at the far end of the backyard where the clotheslines hang. She collects Papa's shirts from the line, which wave in the breeze like misshapen flags. Even in the near darkness, I can see the yellowness of Ekaite's skin. A natural yellow, not like Onyechi's or some of the other girls'. Not like Mama's.

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Eno sits with me. It is late evening, and the sky is grey. Mosquitoes swirl around. *(swats at biting mosquitoes)* At the clothesline, Ekaite is slapping even more than Eno and I. Her skirt only comes down to her knees. *(to Eno)* They bite us all the same.

ENO: *(with angry dejection)* No, they bite Ekaite more. Even the mosquitoes prefer fair skin.

CHINELO: The scent of chlorine billows in the air, and I think of Onyechi. I toss it about in my mind, like a pebble in the air, to get a feel for its texture, its potential, its capacity for success. And then I tell Eno.

When the sky grows black, we go into the house. We cut through the kitchen, pass the dining room, and enter together into the bathroom. Papa and Mama do not catch us. In the bathroom, we pour bleach into the bucket, only a quarter of the way full. Then we watch water bubble out of the faucet. We inhale and exhale deeply, and the sound of our breathing is weirdly louder than the sound of the running water. We turn the faucet off and gaze into the bucket.

EKAITE: Eno . . . Eno!

CHINELO: *(both girls jump)* Eno runs off to answer, more quickly than usual because she knows she should not be in the bathroom with me. She must use the house girls' bathroom, outside in the far corner of the backyard. But mostly, Eno runs off, because dinner will be served in an hour, and Eno will have to help in its preparation.

At the dining table, Papa sits at the head, Mama by his side. The scent of ***egusi*** soup enters through the kitchen. Mama picks up her spoon, looks into it, unscrews the tiny canister, still with the spoon in her hand. The lipstick is a rich colour, red like the hibiscus flower; and it rises from the container slowly, steadily, like a lizard cautiously peeking out of a hole. Overhead the ceiling fan rattles and buzzes. The air conditioner hums, like soft snoring. In the kitchen we hear the clangclanging of food preparation: of the pestle hitting the mortar, yam being pounded for the soup. And then I hear the shutting of the fridge, that shiny, stainless-steel door all the way from America. And I wonder if Ekaite ever takes the time to look at her reflection in the door. And if she does, does she see herself in that superior way in which I imagine all fair people see themselves?

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A bowl of velvet tamarinds sits at the centre of the table. Mama bought the bowl on one of her business trips overseas. She returned from that trip with other things too -- silk blouses from Macy's, Chanel, Nike apparel. The evening she returned, she held up the overseas items for me to see. One blouse she held to my chest. It was the yellow of a ripe pineapple.

MAMA: Will lighten you up. . .

CHINELO: The first magazine arrived two weeks later, *Cosmopolitan,* pale faces and pink lips decorating the cover, women with hair the colour of fresh corn. Next was *Glamour,* then *Elle.*

I remember the bucket in the bathroom, and I feel hope billowing in me. Eno serves our food -- dishes of pounded yam and soup. Mama waves Eno away. I watch her hand waving, the gold rings on her fingers, the bracelet that dangles from her wrist.

MAMA: ***U zoamaka***. You are looking very tattered today. It's no way to present yourself at the dinner table.

CHINELO: The words tumble out of her mouth that American way, one tumbling into the next with no space between. Papa looks at me for a moment, as if for the first time in a long time.

PAPA: How was school today?

MAMA: *(to Papa)* A good week. A good month even. Imagine, an entire month and no strike! Surprising, with the way those lecturers are always on strike. Not to worry. *(pause)* Arrangements are already being made. *(to Chinelo)* You need a good education. That is what America will give you. A solid education. And no strikes. *(smiling widely)* With a degree from America, you can land a job with a big company here, or maybe even remain in America. Land of opportunities. *(pause)* In the meantime, you can't walk around looking tattered, shirt untucked, hair unbrushed. As for your face, dab some powder on. It will help brighten you up. *(clears her throat)* Even Ekaite presents herself better than you do. Very well mannered, that one. Takes care of herself. Beautiful all around.

CHINELO: *(rolling her eyes)* Eno is pretty too.

MAMA: *(mocking in a sing-song)* Eno is pretty too. Eno is no comparison. No comparison at all.

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CHINELO: It's only bias, the way Mama feels about Ekaite. Ekaite's face reminds her of the faces she sees on her magazines. Because, of course, Ekaite's complexion is light and her nose is not as wide and her lips not as thick as mine or Eno's.

I remember the first time [Mama] came back with boxes of those creams. Esoterica, Movate, Skin Success, Ambi. It was around the time television commercials started advertising them -- the fade creams. We'd go to the Everyday Emporium, and there'd be stacks of them at the entrance. It was around this time too that the first set of girls in school started to grow lighter. Mama's friends started to grow lighter, too. Mama did not at first grow light with them. She was cautious. She'd only grow light if she had the best-quality creams, the kinds she knew America would have, not just the brands they sold at the Everyday Emporium.

In just a few weeks, her skin had turned that shade of yellow. She insisted I use the cream too. With Movate, dark and light patches formed all over my skin, like shadows on a wall. She insisted I stop. People would know, she said. Those dark knuckles and kneecaps and eyelids. People would surely know. We tried Esoterica next. No progress at all. Same with Skin Success and Ambi.

I tell Mama that I'm not feeling well and excuse myself from the table before she has a chance to respond. I carry my dishes into the kitchen, where Eno is waiting for me. Inside the bathroom, the air is humid and smells clean, purified, a chemical kind of fresh. Eno holds the towel and stands back, but I call her to me, because I am again finding myself skeptical of the water and bleach. Fear catches me, and I think perhaps we should just pour everything out. But then I hear Mama's voice, saying, ' Eno is no comparison. No comparison at all.' *(taking the towel from Eno)* You should go first. You're not supposed to be here. That way you'll be done by the time anyone comes to chase you out.

(to audience) She gets on her knees so that her face is just above the bucket. *(to Eno)* We'll do only the face today. Only get up when you feel you feel something like a tingle. (*Eno takes a deep breath and dips her face into the water; long pause)* Do you feel it yet? *(Eno*

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shakes her head face still in the water, long pause) Not yet? -- Okay. Come up. *(Eno lifts her face from the water and takes a shuddering breath)*

(to audience) The colour of her skin seems softer, a little lighter than before *(to Eno, smiling)* It's working! But we need to go full force. *(to audience)* The bath bowl is sitting in the sink. I pick it up, pour the bleach straight into it. I call Eno to my side, tell her to place her face into the bowl. *(Eno takes a deep breath and dips her face into the bleach)*

ENO: *(screams and screams)*

CHINELO: Her scream fills the bathroom. There is the thud of the door slamming into the wall. Ekaite rushes towards us. She holds Eno's face in her palms.

ENO: *(twisting her face away, screaming)*

CHINELO: I feel the pain in my own face. Papa looms in the doorway

PAPA: *(fiercely)* What did you do to her? What did you do?

CHINELO: In the doorway, I see Mama just watching. I turn to him, wanting desperately to make my case, but I don't find the words. My legs feel weak. I think of Mama and her creams. *(to Eno)* Don't worry. We'll find something that works. . .

Days later, when the scabs start to form, I imagine peeling them off. Eno's flesh underneath the scabs is reddish-yellow, not quite the yellow of a ripe pawpaw peel. And even if I know that this scabby fairness of hers is borne of injury -- a temporary fairness of skinless flesh, patchy and ugly -- I think how close she has come to having skin like Onyechi's, and I feel something like envy in me, because what she has wound up with ***is*** fairness after all. Fairness, if only for a while.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Chinelo Okparanta
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AWARD HISTORY

2017 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
NIETOC

**** Intro Source and additional information about skin bleaching in African Nations.***

https://files.aho.afro.who.int/afahobckpcontainer/production/files/Skin_Bleaching_in_Africa_regional_fact_sheet_Nov23.pdf

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